

Chapter 41: Truth Doesn't Ask Permission

Jenny didn't like the word he used.

Truth.

It sounded clean.

But nothing about the way it arrived felt clean anymore.

Austin stayed longer than usual that day.

Not in the way he used to—quiet presence, predictable rhythm, familiar silence.

This was different.

He stayed like someone waiting for something to break open.

Jenny hated that feeling.

Because she could feel it too.

When the restaurant slowed, she finally spoke again.

"You keep saying truth," she said.

Austin looked up.

"Yes."

"What truth?"

A pause.

Then—

"The one I've been avoiding."

Jenny frowned.

"That's not an answer."

"It is," he said.

"For now."

That made her exhale sharply.

"You came back different," she said.

"Yes."

"And you're not explaining anything properly."

"I am explaining," he replied.

"I'm just not cushioning it anymore."

Silence.

That word again.

Cushioning.

Like everything before had been softened.

Edited.

Controlled.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"Why stop now?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then—

"Because I don't think I can keep doing that without losing something real."

That landed.

Heavier than expected.

Jenny didn't respond immediately.

A customer called out from the far table.

Jenny ignored it for a second too long.

Bao handled it instead.

Again.

He was watching now.

Not interfering.

Just observing.

Like he knew this was no longer just a conversation.

When Jenny returned, Austin had shifted slightly closer to the counter.

Not invading.

Just less distance than before.

That alone made her more aware of everything.

Her breathing.

Her hands.

Her thoughts.

"You said you needed distance," she said quietly.

"I did."

"And now?"

Austin didn't hesitate.

"I understand what I was trying to separate."

Jenny frowned.

"...And what was that?"

Austin looked at her.

Then said simply,

"You."

Silence.

That word again.

Not emotional this time.

Not poetic.

Just direct.

Jenny blinked.

"...Me?"

"Yes."

A pause.

"I wasn't separating from feelings," he continued.

"I was separating from the fact that they were tied to you."

That made her still.

Jenny lowered her voice.

"And?"

Austin hesitated.

For the first time in a while.

Then—

"I can't separate them anymore."

Silence.

The restaurant felt too quiet again.

Even with people inside it.

Jenny looked at him carefully.

"What does that mean?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"It means I stopped pretending I could control what this is becoming."

Jenny felt something tighten in her chest.

"...And what is it becoming?"

A pause.

Then quietly—

"Something I can't treat as temporary anymore."

That word again.

Temporary.

Jenny swallowed.

"You keep acting like I already agreed to that."

"I know you didn't fully," he said.

"But you didn't leave either."

That hit harder than she expected.

Because it was true.

Jenny looked away.

"I don't like how you say things like that," she muttered.

Austin tilted his head slightly.

"How?"

"Like I'm already inside something I didn't choose."

A pause.

Then softer—

"You are inside it," he said.

"But I didn't put you there alone."

Silence.

That changed the weight of the sentence.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"So what now?" she asked.

Austin didn't answer immediately.

For once, he looked uncertain.

Not lost.

Just no longer controlled.

Then—

"Now I stop pretending I can keep this at a safe distance."

Jenny frowned.

"That doesn't sound safe."

"It isn't," he admitted.

That honesty landed differently.

More dangerous than comforting.

A long pause followed.

Jenny finally spoke again.

"Victoria was part of your truth too?"

Austin nodded.

"Yes."

"And this is... what? New truth?"

A pause.

Then—

"This is the one I'm not stepping away from."

Silence.

Jenny felt her chest tighten again.

Not because it was romantic.

But because it was absolute.

She stepped back slightly.

"You're saying a lot of final-sounding things."

Austin looked at her.

"I am."

"And you think I'm supposed to just... adjust to that?"

A pause.

Then quietly—

"I think you already are."

That made her stop.

Because she couldn't fully deny it.

Not anymore.

For the first time since he returned, Jenny felt something shift in her own response.

Not acceptance.

Not rejection.

Something in between.

Unstable.

Unfinished.

Alive.

She exhaled slowly.

"I need time," she said again.

Austin nodded once.

"I know."

But this time, he added,

"And I'm not leaving it undefined anymore while you do."

Silence.

Jenny looked at him.

And for the first time...

she realized the conversation wasn't about understanding him anymore.

It was about what would still be possible after she did.